Mijbil the Otter

The big idea

In **Mijbil the Otter**, **Gavin Maxwell** describes how he brought an otter from Iraq to London and the funny, loving bond that grew between them. It is a humorous account of a pet with a strong personality.

Summary

- **Getting the otter:** In early 1956 Maxwell went to **Basra, Iraq**, and decided to keep an otter instead of a dog. A friend arranged for one from the **Tigris marshes**. Two Arabs delivered a sack containing a young otter, which Maxwell named **Mijbil**.
- **A new species:** Mijbil belonged to a race unknown to science; zoologists later named it **Maxwell's otter**.
- **Settling in:** For the first 24 hours Mij was aloof and indifferent. Then he started trusting Maxwell. He discovered **water** in the bathtub and went wild with joy, splashing and somersaulting. Within a couple of days he would go to the bathroom by himself and try to turn on the taps.
- **Play:** Mij played with a **rubber ball** and later invented a game of **juggling marbles** on his belly while lying on his back.
- **The journey to London:** British airlines did not allow animals, so Maxwell booked a flight to **Paris** and then London. Mij was to travel in a **box lined with metal**. Before the flight Mij tore the lining and became covered with **blood**. Maxwell rushed to the airport in panic.
- **On the plane:** An **air hostess** kindly let Maxwell keep Mij on his knee. Mij escaped and ran down the aisle, causing chaos among the passengers, one of whom mistook him for a rat. Maxwell lost his dignity crawling under seats but finally caught him.

- **In London:** People guessed what animal Mij was — a **baby seal, a squirrel, a walrus, a hippo, a beaver, a bear cub, a leopard** and even a **brontosaurus**. A labourer asked, "What is it supposed to be?"

WHY THE STORY IS FUNNY

The humour comes from Mij's mischief, Maxwell's embarrassment on the plane and the absurd guesses of Londoners.

Characters

- **Mijbil:** playful, intelligent, curious, loves water, affectionate once he trusts.
- **Gavin Maxwell:** patient, caring, an animal lover with a sense of humour about himself.
- **The air hostess:** kind and understanding.

THE BOX WAS LINED WITH METAL

Mij hurt himself trying to get out of the metal-lined box, not on the aeroplane.

Themes and value points

- Animals respond to love and patience with trust.
- Every creature needs freedom to play and enjoy its nature (water for otters).
- Responsibility of owning a pet.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

Mij's games; why Maxwell had to fly via Paris; the incident in the plane; the guesses of Londoners. Use humorous details in your answers.

Quick recap

- Basra, Iraq, 1956; otter from Tigris marshes named Mijbil; Maxwell's otter.
- Loved water, rubber ball and juggling marbles.
- Flight via Paris; metal-lined box; chaos on the plane; kind air hostess.
- Funny guesses in London: seal, walrus, hippo, brontosaurus.

Practice questions

1. Where did Gavin Maxwell get Mijbil?
   (a) In London (b) Near Basra, from the Tigris marshes in Iraq (c) In Paris (d) In Egypt
2. Mij's species was later named
   (a) the Tigris otter (b) the London otter (c) Maxwell's otter (d) the river seal
3. What did Mij discover that made him wild with joy?
   (a) A rubber ball (b) Water in the bathtub (c) Marbles (d) Fish
4. Why did Maxwell fly to London via Paris?
   (a) It was cheaper (b) He had work in Paris (c) Mij liked Paris (d) The British airline did not allow animals on its flight
5. What did Mij do in the box before the flight?
   (a) He slept peacefully (b) He tore the lining and became bloodstained (c) He ate his food (d) He escaped through the window
6. Which of these was NOT a guess made by Londoners about Mij?
   (a) A walrus (b) A baby seal (c) A brontosaurus (d) A kangaroo
7. Describe the games Mij played.
8. Narrate the incident on the aeroplane. How did the air hostess help?

Answers: 1. b 2. c 3. b 4. d 5. b 6. d 7. see notes 8. see notes